

CITY PRIMAEVAL
'Under a Clear Blue Sky' (oil on canvas, 2024) by Sudhir Patwardhan

demolished site. While a bulldozer lurks, apparently to scoop the next pile of debris, he contemplates the pieces of his destroyed home.

In a similar vein is the work 'Built and Broken' (2024). It shows many features of modern cities, like high-rise buildings, flyovers, metro-lines, housing complexes and expressways. "These aspects of the ultra-modern metropolis are usually projected as a development utopia. This is contrasted, at the centre of the painting, with a vision of cities being destroyed, lives shattered—what we have been seeing over the past few years. Could the swirling expressway in the centre be a path to doom?" asks Patwardhan.

What's striking is that there is hardly any visible nostalgia for the elegant structures of the city's past in their Art Deco or Victorian Gothic glory. Rather, the paintings of sprawling blocks and semi-constructed buildings seem to mark a colossal social churn. The visceral realism explores various asymmetries, including class struggles, tension between the material and spiritual and the emotional theatre of community. The slice-of-life scenes offer a moving portrait of the bustling annals of the city. Is this a form of activism or merely social commentary? "I do not see my art as activism. I do not think art changes anything externally. It can only change one's perception of oneself and of how one sees the world. I do not set out to comment on anything. I set out to understand my own perceptions of my surroundings and of myself. This does result in a kind of social commentary as I am a social being," says Patwardhan. ■

STRIKINGLY, THERE IS HARDLY ANY NOSTALGIA FOR MUMBAI'S OLD, ELEGANT STRUCTURES HERE. RATHER, SPRAWLING BLOCKS AND SEMI-CONSTRUCTED BUILDINGS MARK SOCIAL CHURN

–Prachi Joshi

Cities: Built, Broken will be shown at **Jehangir Art Gallery** (Mumbai, Mar. 25-31), **TRI Art & Culture** (Kolkata, April 16-June 29) and **Durbar Hall Art Gallery, Ernakulam** (Kochi, Sept. 6-30)

In a half-century long career, Correa built museums, state assembly buildings, apartments, churches as well as ashrams—an architecture exceptionally made, truly experimental, and displaying rare thought and unusual insights. The Gandhi Museum in Ahmedabad is a meticulous transformation of Euclidean geometry into a structure of light and shade; the Kanchanjunga Apartments, an unusual sandwich of a bungalow verandah applied to high-rise living. Both, uniquely Correa designs.

Yet, whatever he did, there always lurked at the back of his mind the nagging tension that he was working in a poor country with limited resources. Without a clear vision that included the urban poor, the professional could hardly affect real change. Despite this baffling contradiction, Correa's line of thinking and his level of social involvement grew with every project. The daily sight of squalor and destitution in and around the Bombay of his home and office provided him an opportunity to address urban problems, and as he often did, also raising every task to a level of joyful creation. A proposal for the prime minister's residence conceived as a bamboo and mud courtyard, surrounded by bamboo cells for foreign dignitaries was for Correa an 'introduction to foreign visitors of a simpler way of life' and a true reflection of a poor country.

The daily sight of squalor in Bombay allowed the socially conscious **Correa** to address urban problems

So keen and clear headed an observer of Indian living conditions, Correa worked at a time when the architect occupied a respectable position in society—a role that not merely involved design and construction of buildings but drove the architect deep into examining social and cultural ideals. His designs for the homeless for the streets of Mumbai and those for a peaceful resolution to the Babri Masjid demolition—like the PM's residence—remained sadly un-built, as were other proposals on land reclamation. Because all his urban work was filled with design innovation and social responsibility, Correa's disappointments were a real loss for India. His absence has made the profession one dimensional, and the poor poorer. ■

–Gautam Bhatia